

PATHS TO PROSPERITY

The Centre and the state have to stop quibbling over who should build roads. Indian agriculture cannot afford to lose more time.



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Whenever I am asked on how the gap between India and Bharat can be bridged, John Kennedy's famous words come to my mind: "American roads are not good because America is rich, but America is rich because American roads are good." In these very words lie the solution to India's problems. Rural-urban road connectivity is one of the country's most significant issues. When Atal Bihari Vajpayee became the prime minister, for the first time a committee was formed to consider this vital issue. I was fortunate enough to become the Chairman of the National Rural Road Development Committee.

Roads create prosperity and play a major role in connecting Bharat with India. Lots of difficulties are waiting in the path, but overcoming them should be our true goal. I always say: "If there is a will there is a way. If there is no will there are only surveys, discussions and research groups." However, despite all efforts, about 35 per cent of all targeted habitations still remain to be connected by roads according to available data by end-March 2007.

► **The Centre should finance village road connectivity** Industries and trade are absent in villages. This causes unemployment. One of the biggest issues that agriculture in India is facing is of reach. Even if our farmers produce substantial quantities of crops, they are not able to market them in urban centres. Thanks to the Mumbai-Pune Express Highway, places like Kolhapur, Satara and Sangli are now merely five hours away from Mumbai. It's important that special tracks or highways be built to benefit agro industry.

► **Grow regionally available crops in the area and establish related industries** It is the need of the hour. The budget necessary for growing such crops and trees should be provided. If Rs 10 is provided for every plant, then after four years when the tree bears fruit, the builder can take half the produce and the village panchayat the remaining. This scheme can provide income to 40-50 lakh villagers.

► **Establish small bio-diesel industries** If trees such as Saal and Moh, which produce this fuel, are grown on barren land, it will help. Further, building hospitals and schools will improve the quality of life and create new employment opportunities in villages. Industries should be encouraged in the villages where natural wealth such as minerals and forest products are available on large scale.

► **Innovative thinking is required to raise funds** We should consider getting funds from rural development fund schemes and the World Bank. Over Rs 5,60,000 crore has been spent on public sector enterprises and most of them are running at a loss. Therefore, the Government should instead spend on road networks.

► **Develop eco-tourism, agro-tourism and water sports** It will attract tourists.

It's about time that states and the Centre stop the debate on who should build the village and district roads. No more time should be wasted if India wants to dream of a prosperous future.

as told to Mallni Bhupta

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